

Grade 9

B.E.S.T. Writing

Sample Test Materials

The purpose of these sample test materials is to orient teachers and students to the appearance of passages and prompts on paper-based accommodated B.E.S.T. Writing tests. Each spring, students in grades 4–10 are administered one text-based writing prompt for the B.E.S.T. Writing test. Students will respond to either an expository prompt or to an argumentative prompt. An example of a text-based writing prompt for each grade is available for practice. To familiarize students with the response formats, teachers may encourage students to practice with each type of prompt within a grade band.

The following B.E.S.T. Writing sample test materials are available on the Florida Statewide Assessments Portal as shown below:

Elementary Grade Band

Grade 4 - Expository

Grade 5 - Argumentative

Middle Grade Band

Grade 6 - Expository

Grade 7 - Argumentative

Grade 8 - Expository

High School Grade Band

Grade 9 - Argumentative

Grade 10 - Expository

The sample test materials are not intended to guide classroom instruction.

Writing Prompt

Write an argumentative essay about whether community service should be a requirement for high school students.

Your argumentative essay must be based on this prompt and topic, and it must incorporate ideas and evidence found in the sources provided.

Use your best writing to complete an essay that

- is focused on your position;
- combines evidence from multiple sources with your own elaboration to develop your ideas;
- rebuts counterclaims with evidence;
- is organized and includes transitions within and among ideas;
- provides citations for quoted material and source ideas; and
- demonstrates correct use of grammar and language appropriate to the task.

Write your multiparagraph essay to an academic audience in the space provided.

Read the “Community Service” sources.

Community Service

Source 1: Should Community Service Be a Requirement?

by Diana Redly

- 1 High schools across the country are requiring that their students complete community service hours. This has been a topic of debate, because some believe that volunteering shouldn't be something that students are forced to do. Volunteering, after all, should be voluntary, shouldn't it?
- 2 Studies have shown that students who participate in community service tend to get better grades. This may be due to learning opportunities presented by service projects, or a heightened sense of belonging. Studies have also shown that individuals who volunteer tend to be healthier and happier than those who don't.
- 3 Volunteering also strengthens college applications. In a survey of college admissions officers, 84 percent said that “a student's community service has a positive impact on acceptance to our higher education institution.” Colleges seek students who understand the value of helping others and have good time management skills. Being involved in community service outside of school hours while balancing schoolwork shows a high level of responsibility.
- 4 Participating in community service also builds career-readiness skills like collaboration, communication, and leadership. If students learn how to work well with others while volunteering in high school, they will be better prepared for the professional world.
- 5 However, there are many high school students who are already part of the workforce. Afterschool jobs can teach students the same skills that unpaid volunteer opportunities do. Students who hold jobs might find it challenging to also complete the number of volunteer hours required by the school. This can make community service feel like a burden rather than an enjoyable and meaningful experience.
- 6 While requiring students to participate in community service may create a sense of civic responsibility, students do not necessarily carry

this with them after graduation. One study by the National Center for Education Statistics reported that after high school, young adults were less active as community service members. In fact, eight years after graduation, volunteerism declined by 25 percent. When community service is no longer mandatory, young people may lose motivation to spend their limited free time volunteering.

- 7 Yet, the communities themselves greatly benefit from youth volunteerism. For example, teens across Florida develop their own service projects as a component of their International Baccalaureate program. At one school in South Florida, teachers encourage students to be creative with their projects and choose something that they are passionate about. One group of high school students developed a program to give free music lessons to children in the community. These children were eager to work with the students and gained an appreciation for the arts. Another student group organized community walks to raise money for local charities. These walks will continue to raise more and more money as incoming students offer new ideas.

"Should Community Service Be a Requirement?" by Diana Redly. Written for educational purposes.

Source 2: High school seniors in mad scramble to finish community service

by Donna St. George

- 8 Mary Wagner gets insistent with her students at this time of year. It's 10 weeks until graduation day, and she's been nudging seniors at James Hubert Blake High School in Silver Spring to finish their community service hours.
- 9 "We keep making it clear: This is not optional," says Wagner, whose last count showed 93 of the school's 378 seniors had come up short on the Maryland state graduation requirement.
- 10 In many schools in the Washington [D.C.] region, community service hours take on a new-found urgency in spring, as students nearing graduation look to put in time at soup kitchens, charitable events, libraries, parks, recreation centers and retirement homes. . . .
- 11 In D.C., Peter MacPherson, a parent and Ward 6 education activist, said the service requirement is worthwhile but can be daunting. His daughter, involved in a rigorous academic program at School Without Walls and competitive swimming for many years, has put in more than

- 35 hours since January, helping at a library, a school, a science fair, a pet adoption event and a museum, as well as tutoring children, he said.
- 12 "It's a scramble," he said.
- 13 At Montgomery's Clarksburg High School, Natoscha McKinnon, head of the counseling department, also notes that many students have competing obligations. For some, jobs and family responsibilities are a priority, she said. "They understand the importance of it," she said. "It's just a matter of finding time to fit it in." . . .
- 14 In D.C., Benjamin Banneker Academic High School requires 270 hours of service. In Montgomery, students who earn 260 hours or more are recognized with a purple tassel at graduation. In Prince George's, students with extra hours are eligible to compete for a scholarship.
- 15 "We're teaching them global citizenship and how you give back to the community," said Banneker Principal Anita Berger.
- 16 Karen Osorio, a 17-year-old senior in Prince George's County, says she has completed nearly 200 hours, working at an elementary school in the summer and with a softball team for developmentally disabled students.
- 17 "I always think it's good to give back to the community and also to gain experience," she said, pointing out that she has learned workplace skills she would not have otherwise acquired.
- 18 At Blake High School, Wagner, the school's coordinator for student-service learning hours, says seniors and their families are notified of outstanding service requirements in a variety of ways, including letters, robocalls and meetings.
- 19 Many students consult the county's volunteer center Web site for opportunities. But Wagner also has created a wall for service opportunities just outside her classroom.
- 20 One recent day, she checked in with several seniors during lunch. "What are you going to do?" she asked, looking for specifics.
- 21 One student said he had done many hours but neglected to hand in his paperwork.
- 22 Tyrone Okunoren, 18, said he had two service gigs, one at his younger brother's elementary school and another at the National Capital Trolley Museum. He was nearly done, he said.
- 23 "At first I thought it was going to be a chore," he recalled. "But after

the first week, I started to get into it.” He says the work gives him a view beyond the classroom: “It kind of lets me take a break from academics and focus on the real world.”

Excerpt from “High school seniors in mad scramble to finish community service” by Donna St. George. Copyright © 2015 by the Washington Post. Reprinted by permission of the Washington Post via Copyright Clearance Center.

Source 3: The Benefits of Volunteerism, if the Service is Real

by Alina Tugend

- 24 Nowadays, some sort of volunteerism is a given in many places. Through schools, churches, synagogues, Girl and Boy Scouts and countless other organizations, children and teenagers are expected to do something, whether it be fund-raising for charities, working at soup kitchens or assisting at animal shelters.
- 25 In the most positive light, such service teaches children and teenagers to look beyond themselves and understand the role they can play in their community and country. In the most negative light, it is one more activity to tick off en route to college.
- 26 “There is some cynicism¹ among people that some portion of community service is prompted by students interested more in résumé-building,” said Richard G. Niemi, professor of political science at the University of Rochester.
- 27 But does it really matter why it’s done? Isn’t it enough to volunteer, no matter the motive?
- 28 Well, yes and no. Studies have shown that generally, community service for whatever reason is a good thing. But how it’s done and whether it also involves service learning—that is, lessons that discuss homelessness, say, or hunger in a larger context—make a difference.
- 29 Joseph E. Kahne, a professor of education at Mills College, and his colleagues just completed a survey of more than 500 teenagers in the 11th and 12th grades from a diverse set of 19 high schools in California. The researchers followed the students for up to three years after graduation.
- 30 The students who were engaged in some sort of community service

¹cynicism: a belief that people are selfish and dishonest

in high school—whether mandatory or voluntary—were more likely to volunteer or be involved in some civic activity. Most, but not all, of the volunteer work had classroom learning attached to it.

- 31 Participants get much more out of the work they do, Professor Niemi said, if there is a forum to talk about and question the larger issues involved.
- 32 Otherwise, he said, students may believe that all problems are solved through individual efforts and government doesn't have a role. "They'll see that the homeless don't have food and that individuals help, but they won't understand the connection between public policy and the homeless," he said. . . .
- 33 In fact, if teenagers—and adults for that matter—are thrust in a volunteer situation they don't understand or feel that they are simply being assigned made-up work, it can actually have a detrimental effect.
- 34 James E. Youniss, a research professor of psychology at the Catholic University of America, said an unpublished study of New York students discovered that they were actually turned off to community service when they were told they were going to help people and ended up doing menial jobs that seemed unrelated.
- 35 Of course, volunteering may involve mundane or repetitive work, but those participating need to understand the connection between their work and the overall issue, Professor Youniss said.
- 36 "It's not that service is bad, but that programs can be bad," he said.
- 37 Because of time constraints and concerns about overt political messages, it can be difficult to create programs that offer the insights along with community service, Professor Youniss added.
- 38 But that doesn't mean schools and organizations—not to mention parents—should stop encouraging or even requiring children to volunteer. Professor Youniss studied students in one Massachusetts high school that was about to introduce mandatory community service.
- 39 He looked at a sample group of teenagers, including those who did no volunteering, those who did so on their own and those required to complete a certain number of hours by their senior year.
- 40 The students were asked at the beginning and end of their high school career if they were likely to vote when they became eligible and do some sort of community service. Those who weren't volunteering, or weren't required to, usually said they were unlikely to vote or do

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community service in the future. Those who volunteered without being required generally said they were likely to vote and would volunteer.

41 But the big switch to being much more inclined to volunteer and vote was apparent among those students who had been assigned service in the community, Professor Youniss said.

42 "I remember one kid who was a fullback, who waited until his senior year to volunteer," he said. "Then he filled the 40-hour requirement by every Saturday taking a blind man to a gym and walking him through his physical activity." That changed the boy's outlook on his role in the community and helping others, Professor Youniss said.

Excerpt from "The Benefits of Volunteerism, if the Service Is Real" by Alina Tugend. Copyright © 2019 by the New York Times. Reprinted by permission of the New York Times via Copyright Clearance Center.

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Lined writing area with 25 horizontal lines.

A large rectangular area with horizontal lines for writing.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.